

Brassica oleracea (Brassicaceae)

Cabbage

Description Biennial or perennial herb growing to 8 ft (2.5 m). Has a thick stem, grey leaves, and 4-petaled yellow flowers. Within the first year, it produces a greatly enlarged terminal bud that develops into the familiar cabbage head in late summer.

Habitat & Cultivation Wild cabbage is native to coasts of the English Channel and the Mediterranean. Cultivated varieties are produced worldwide as a vegetable.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Cabbage is rich in vitamins A, B₁, B₂, and C.

History & Folklore The wholesome cabbage is one of the oldest vegetables. According to Greek myth, the plant sprang into existence from the perspiration of Zeus. In a Greek ritual, cabbage was given to expectant mothers shortly before birth in order to establish good breast-milk production. The Romans used cabbage as an antidote, especially to alcohol, believing it countered intoxication and prevented or reduced a hangover. They also used cabbage leaves to cleanse infected wounds. It is thought to have been cultivated in Britain from around 500 CE.

One traditional method of making a cabbage poultice, still used today, is to cut out the thick midrib of a leaf and iron it, placing it while still hot on the area to be treated.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Cabbage's best-known medicinal use is as a poultice—the leaves of the wild or cultivated plant are blanched, crushed, or chopped, and applied to swellings, tumors, and painful joints. Wild cabbage leaves eaten raw or cooked aid digestion and the breakdown of toxins in the liver—so the Romans' eating it to ease a hangover was in fact quite justified. Cabbage is also detoxifying and helpful in the long-term treatment of arthritis. The high vitamin C content of cabbage has made it useful in the prevention of scurvy.

Caution A cabbage poultice may cause blisters if left on for several hours.

Bryonia dioica syn. *B. cretica* subsp. *dioica* (Cucurbitaceae)

White Bryony

Description Perennial climbing vine with fleshy taproot up to 6 in (15 cm) thick. Straggling stem with tendrils, greenish flowers, and red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation White bryony is native

to southern England and parts of Europe. The root is dug up in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents White bryony contains cucurbitacins, glycosides, volatile oil, and tannins. The cucurbitacins kill cells and so act on tumors.

History & Folklore From prehistory to the Middle Ages, the thick roots of white bryony were cut into a human shape as a substitute (or a counterfeit) for mandrake root (*Mandragora officinarum*, p. 232), which was believed to afford magical protection. The Greek physician Dioscorides (1st century CE) reports that the leaves, fruit, and root of white bryony were applied to gangrenous wounds. In medieval England, the plant was used to treat leprosy.



White bryony has antitumor and antirheumatic properties.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A powerful cathartic and purgative, bryony is used with great caution in herbal medicine today. It is principally prescribed for painful rheumatic conditions. It may be taken internally, or applied as a counterirritant, causing swelling and increased blood flow to the area. White bryony is also given for other inflammatory conditions such as duodenal ulcers, asthma, bronchitis, and pleurisy, and may be used to reduce high blood pressure. The whole herb has antiviral activity and research is now suggesting that it acts as an adaptogen—helping the body to adapt more effectively to stress and strain.

Related Species *B. alba* is used in homeopathic medicine. Black bryony (*Tamus communis*) is an unrelated plant with approximately similar uses.

⚠️ Cautions Bryony is a toxic plant. Use only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Butea monosperma (Fabaceae)Palas,
Flame of the Forest,
Bengal Kino

Description Deciduous tree growing to 49 ft (15 m). Has 3-lobed leaves and large orange-red flowers in clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Palas is native to India and Southeast Asia. It grows in forests and in open areas to altitudes of 3,900 ft (1,200 m).

Parts Used Bark, flowers, leaves, gum, and seeds.

Constituents All parts of the tree except the seeds contain tannins.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The gum that oozes from incisions made in palas bark is known as Bengal kino. Mildly astringent, it is used as a substitute for the kino derived from bastard teak (*Pterocarpus marsupium*). Bengal kino is taken as a decoction or a tincture for acid indigestion, diarrhea, and dysentery, and used as a gargle for sore throats and as a douche for vaginitis. Early research suggests that the leaves and bark have the potential to treat diabetes, and that the leaves exert a beneficial action on diarrhea.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Caesalpinia bonduc (Caesalpinaceae)

Nikkar Nut

Description Thorny bush growing to 30 ft (9 m), with spiny compound leaves, yellow flowers in dense clusters, and prickly pods containing yellow seeds (nuts).

Habitat & Cultivation Nikkar nut is pan-tropical, common in both tropical Asia and Africa. Its seeds are gathered when ripe.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents The seeds contain isoflavonoids, diterpenes, a bitter principle, and a fixed oil (20%) rich in linoleic acid (68%).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Nikkar seeds are used to treat fevers and are taken as a tonic and aphrodisiac. In India, they are often mixed with black pepper (*Piper nigrum*, p. 250) for medicinal use. The seeds are also taken for inflammatory conditions such as arthritis. Roasted nikkar seeds are used in the treatment of diabetes.